

JAPAN'S NATIONAL TREASURES

Himeji Castle

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The White Heron Castle — white-plastered, wide-winged, still standing after four centuries and two brushes with destruction. A guide to reading Japan's most complete castle on foot.

THE FIVE NATIONAL TREASURE CASTLES / VOLUME ONE

Before you go

Admission fees, opening hours and access arrangements described in this book are subject to change. Always check the official website for the latest information before visiting.

Himeji Castle official site: <https://www.city.himeji.lg.jp/castle/>

Basic Data

At a glance

Name	Himeji Castle (Himeji-jo) — also known as Shirasagi-jo, the White Heron Castle
Location	68 Honmachi, Himeji, Hyogo Prefecture
Type	Architecture — castle and keep
National Treasure	Designated 1931 under the old system; re-designated 1951
World Heritage	Inscribed December 1993 — among Japan's first UNESCO World Heritage Sites
The keep	Main keep of five roofs and six floors over a basement, plus three smaller keeps, linked into a connected complex
Present form	Completed around 1609 in the great rebuilding by Ikeda Terumasa

| How this book is arranged

- ▶ Chapter 1 — History: three lords and two brushes with destruction
- ▶ Chapter 2 — Reading the architecture: why the White Heron is both beautiful and strong
- ▶ Chapter 3 — Walking the castle: a route guide
- ▶ Chapter 4 — Visiting: hours, access, seasons and the neighbourhood

Written to work either way round — read it before you go, or read it again after you have been. Once you know what the walls and stones were for, the same stone base and the same white plaster look completely different.

History — three lords, two brushes with destruction

| From fort to great castle

Himeji Castle traces its origin to 1333, when Akamatsu, a warrior of Harima province, is said to have raised a fort on this hill. Over the centuries that followed, forty-eight lords from thirteen families held the site in turn. It commanded the approaches to western Japan, and whoever held it held a piece of the country's balance of power.

Three lords in particular gave the castle the shape we see today.

- **Hashiba (Toyotomi) Hideyoshi** — built a three-storey keep here as a base for his western campaigns
- **Ikeda Terumasa** — took the castle after the Battle of Sekigahara and spent roughly eight years from 1601 rebuilding it into the present main keep of five roofs and six floors
- **Honda Tadamasa** — arrived in 1617 and laid out the third bailey and the western bailey, completing the castle as it now stands

| Princess Sen

Honda Tadamasa had a reason for building the western bailey: it was for **Princess Sen**, who had married his eldest son Tadatoki. A granddaughter of Tokugawa Ieyasu, she had lost her first husband, Toyotomi Hideyori, at the fall of Osaka Castle, and came here to live after remarrying. The Cosmetic Tower and the Long Corridor that survive in the western bailey still carry something of her daily life — a reminder that a castle was not only a machine for war.



| First threat: the Meiji abolition of castles

With the return of the domains to the emperor in 1869, Himeji Castle became state property. It passed to the army as a military installation, and in 1872 the government decided which of the country's castles would be kept and which demolished. Himeji was marked for preservation — but the upkeep was ruinous and the fabric was decaying, and **the paperwork for demolition began to move** all the same.

What saved it was an army officer who urged its preservation on the occasion of an imperial progress. The removal, all but decided, was suspended, and the castle survived.

A note — the castle sold for a song

A story is often told that in these years Himeji Castle went to auction and was knocked down for an astonishingly small sum. Accounts of the figure differ — the famous one is 23 yen 50 sen — and it is said that the buyer never demolished it because disposing of the roof tiles alone would have cost more than the castle was worth. Whether or not the details are true, the story captures how thoroughly castles had come to be seen as useless relics.

| Second threat: the war

In 1945 Himeji was bombed twice — on 22 June, and again through the night of 3 July into the early hours of the 4th. The city centre burned to the ground and more than five hundred people were killed.

And yet — **the castle did not burn**. An incendiary that fell on the keep failed to detonate; the castle had been draped in black netting; explanations are offered, but no one has settled the matter. For people who had lost everything, the sight of the castle standing white and whole above the ashes became something to hold on to.

| Rebuilt to survive — two great restorations

In the **Showa restoration**, begun in 1956, the keep was **dismantled completely**, its timbers repaired and the whole reassembled — an undertaking without precedent. Of the two great pillars running from the basement to the top floor, the eastern one had leaned out of true by 37 centimetres, and the western one had rotted through to the core and had to be replaced with new timber. The keep alone cost some 530 million yen.

The **Heisei restoration**, from June 2009 to March 2015, renewed the white plaster, replaced the roof tiles and strengthened the structure against earthquakes, at a cost of about 2.8 billion yen. For a while afterwards people joked that the castle had come back *too* white.

Himeji has not simply stood for four hundred years. **It stands because each generation has taken it apart and put it back together.** That is the castle's other story.

Reading the architecture



On the left, the western and northwestern smaller keeps with their connecting corridors; on the right, the main keep. Linked all the way round, they enclose a courtyard between them. Early morning in summer.

| The connected keep

Himeji's defining feature is its **connected keep**: a main keep with three smaller keeps joined to it by roofed corridors, forming a closed ring. The ring encloses a courtyard, and an attacker who broke in would find himself trapped there, exposed on every side. **Beauty and defence solved in a single move** — this is why the design is regarded as the high point of Japanese castle architecture.

| Plastered white, inside and out

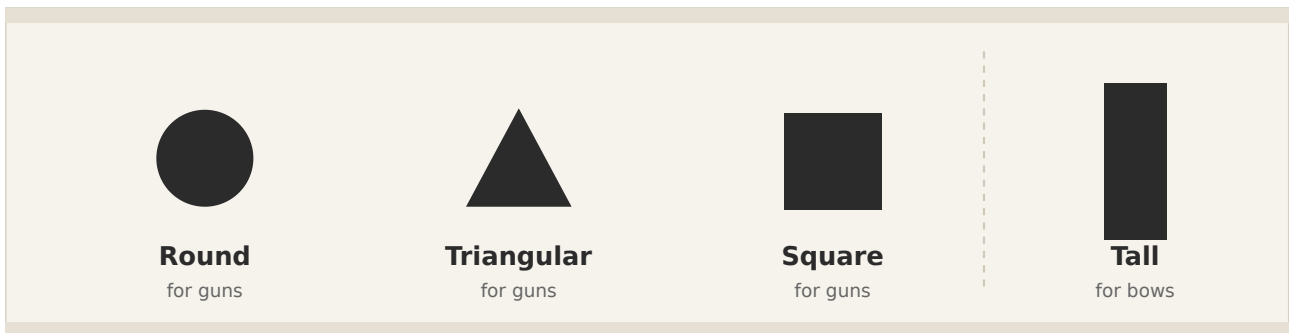
Not only the walls but the eaves and even the joints between roof tiles are sealed with white lime plaster. This is the whiteness that earned the castle its heron's name — and it is not only for looks. **The plaster is fireproofing**. When the castle emerged from its recent restoration looking startlingly bright, it was because that coating had just been renewed.

| A path built as a maze

The route from the main gate to the keep bends and doubles back on purpose. Every gate turns you a different way; nothing runs straight. The point was to break an attack's momentum, buy time, and keep the attackers under fire from above. Walk it imagining yourself on the attacking side and the design starts to make sense.

The catch is that **you cannot see any of this while you are inside it**. From the ground you cannot tell which way you are facing or where in the castle you are. Look again at the painting on the previous page: the moats ring the hill, the baileys fold back on one another, and the path climbs by turns to the keep. Seen from above, the maze is obvious.

| Defences worth looking for



Types of loophole. Round, triangular and square openings were for guns; the tall rectangle was for bows. (Original diagram)

Loopholes are the small openings cut through the walls for guns and bows. Round, triangular and square ones were for firearms; the tall rectangular ones were for archers, who needed vertical room to draw a bow. **997** loopholes survive in the inner enclosures of Himeji — 844 for guns and 153 for bows. Look up at the walls and you will start to notice the difference in shape.

Stone drops are openings in the floor of sections that jut out from the wall, through which stones or boiling water could be dropped straight down onto anyone climbing the base.

The **stonework** repays attention too. The method changes from era to era — from rough natural stones stacked as found, to blocks dressed to fit without a gap. You can read the progress of the craft within a single castle.

Walking the castle

- ▶ Main Gate — enter here
- ▶ Third Bailey lawn — the classic head-on view of the keep
- ▶ Diamond Gate — a tower gate with Momoyama-period ornament
- ▶ The I Gate and the Ro Gate — climbing through the turns
- ▶ Bizenmaru — the keep seen from directly below
- ▶ The main keep — basement to top floor
- ▶ The western bailey — Long Corridor and Cosmetic Tower

Plan	Time	What you see
Quick	1-1.5 hours	The main keep and the essentials
Standard	About 2 hours	Main keep plus the western bailey
Unhurried	3-4 hours	Gates, towers and stonework, and the garden next door

Before you set off

In peak season there can be a wait to enter the keep. During cherry-blossom season and public holidays, arriving right at opening time is the way to avoid it. The stairs inside the keep are steep, so wear shoes you can climb in and carry a bag that leaves both hands free.

| Along the way



The Diamond Gate, the first tower gate you meet after entering. The latticed windows, black-lacquered and fitted with gilded mounts, preserve the ornamental taste of the Momoyama period.



The keep complex seen from Bizenmaru. This is where the stonework is at its most imposing — and where the climb you have just made finally explains itself.

Every gate changes what you can see. You turn, you climb, you turn again — and when the keep finally rises above you at the end of it, the reason this castle was built the way it was needs no explaining.

Visiting

Admission

Open	9:00–17:00 (last admission 16:00)
Admission	1,000 yen for adults; a combined ticket with Koko-en garden is available
Access inside	Open year-round; the interior of the keep can be visited
Official site	https://www.city.himeji.lg.jp/castle/

Fees and hours change. Please check the official website before you travel.

Getting there

Nearest station	JR Himeji Station, or Sanyo-Himeji Station on the Sanyo Electric Railway
On foot	About 20 minutes straight up Otemae-dori from the station's north exit — the castle is visible ahead of you the whole way
By bus	Shinki Bus from the north exit to Otemon-mae, then about 5 minutes on foot
By car	Municipal car parks nearby (paid)
By Shinkansen	JR Himeji Station is served directly

The castle through the year

Spring	Cherry blossom. The grounds and the western bailey are among the finest viewing spots anywhere — white walls against pink
Summer	Deep green against white plaster; the castle changes colour as the light goes
Autumn	Maples in Koko-en, with the keep rising beyond the garden
Winter	Clear air and a hard-edged silhouette. Snow on the roofs is rare and worth seeing



| Next door — Koko-en

Laid out on the site of the lord's western residence, Koko-en is a stroll garden built around ponds, divided into nine gardens each with its own character, with a tea house and a restaurant. A combined ticket with the castle makes it the natural second stop. The white walls of Himeji borrowed as a backdrop are a favourite with photographers.



The gate to the Garden of the Flowering Trees. Its tiled roof frames the garden beyond like a picture.



Maples and a thatched pavilion reflected in the pond. In autumn the garden holds a quiet quite unlike the castle's.

| Local food

- **Himeji oden** — eaten the local way, dipped in **ginger soy sauce**, which cuts through the light Kansai broth beautifully
- **Conger eel** — the Harima Sea is prime conger ground, and the large **densuke anago** is a Himeji speciality
- **Souvenirs** — the station building carries rolled conger, packaged Himeji oden and local confectionery

| Where to photograph

- **Third Bailey lawn** — the whole keep head-on; the classic shot
- **Bizenmaru** — looking up, with the full weight of the stonework in frame
- **From Koko-en** — white walls seen over the green of the garden
- **The moat and the town** — blossom, autumn colour and evening illumination each change the picture completely

For a second visit

The Long Corridor in the western bailey, the loopholes, the stone drops — the features this book could only describe in words and diagrams are all things you can photograph yourself inside the castle. Next time, go and take your own.

Credits and notes

Image credits

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The keep from Bizenmaru — Mat, Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons

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Koko-en, garden gate — **663highland, CC BY 2.5**, via Wikimedia Commons

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Diagram, “Types of loophole” — original to this book

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Principal sources

Himeji Castle official site (City of Himeji) — <https://www.city.himeji.lg.jp/castle/>

Cultural Heritage Online (Agency for Cultural Affairs) — <https://online.bunka.go.jp/>

Koko-en (Himeji City Machizukuri Promotion Organization)

Japan’s National Treasures — Himeji Castle

The Five National Treasure Castles, Volume One

Only five castle keeps in Japan are designated National Treasures:

Himeji, Matsumoto, Inuyama, Hikone and Matsue. This series visits each of them in turn.